



serving their own insecurities and need for power but the consequences on the psyche of the athlete are disastrous. Every year, the announcement of our sports budget, historically minuscule, added further humiliation to our athletes and reinforced the psychological scars inflicted upon them by the establishment.

The fact that it was Paes, who first brought home an individual Olympic medal, provides substantial proof of the validity of this theory. He was far removed from the system and in a sport which offered huge prize money. His father, Vece

itive signals to the sports federations and specifically to the athletes as a lot of the funds are meant specifically for their training. Tax-free cash awards for medal winners in the Commonwealth, Asian Games, Olympics and other World championships of those not in the Olympics have been put in place over the last 10 years. Bindra received Rs 1 crore for his Beijing gold. The media has begun to highlight the achievement of our Olympians and also raises issues when athletes are exploited.

Our political system is coming to terms with the fact that sport must be encouraged more pro-actively and cannot be sidelined with the argument that money must go towards eradicating poverty and providing electricity and jobs to our masses. Those plans are anyway in place including the money even though the flawed execution and inherent corruption in our system severely slows the entire process. Government today realises that success in sport massages a billion people's ego and it somehow brings us together as one in these times when factionalism, religious discord and terrorism are the norm rather than the exception. The Indian flag being raised with the 'Jana Gana Mana' being

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If we get our act together, tap the grassroots and plan methodically, we can make the great leap—10 medals in a single Olympics—in 10-12 years.

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ABHINAV BINDRA
Olympic Gold Medallist

INDIA TODAY



THE STORIES OF PAES, RATHORE AND BINDRA PROVE THAT GIVEN SUFFICIENT RESOURCES, DIGNITY AND SELF-WORTH OUR ATHLETES CAN PERFORM AT THE HIGHEST LEVEL.

Paes, took huge loans to fund his son's professional needs and the rest was history. By winning in the international arena Leander soon earned enough titles, money and honour to never have to bow down to any official. The stories of Rajyavardhan Singh Rathore and Abhinav Bindra provide further proof that given sufficient resources, dignity and self-worth, our athletes can perform at the highest level.

Rathore, an army major in 2004, received support from the Army, and won a silver medal at the Athens Olympics. That silver medal was instrumental in providing much-needed subconscious belief to the shooters who followed. Bindra, with loads of financial and emotional support from his family and living in an era when the sports ministry was provided more funds, both for infrastructure and for training, kept his cool in Beijing to win the gold medal and become India's definitive sporting hero.

The recent sports budget for 2009-10 is Rs 3,073 crore, a massive increase over the last. This is heartening and has already sent out pos-

played as the talented Bindra received his gold medal at Beijing did more for our collective pride than any global treaty, nuclear agreement or political achievement. The benefits of most treatise and political achievements are experienced by future generations. Bindra's victory provided instantaneous gratification to the people of a country starved of success in the international arena.

The positive trend is firmly in place. Recently, I heard the heartening story of how swiftly the government had moved to help injured hockey goalkeeper Baljit Singh. Within 48 hours, his father was issued a passport and the two of them had visas to travel to the the United States for further treatment. The tide is turning. Unlike most financial analysts, who predict the movement of the Sensex and Nifty through technical charts with various caveats, I am ready to stick my neck out and predict that we will come back with at least two gold medals from the 2012 London Olympics, five gold medals by 2016. And by 2020, we will be a sporting power with at least 10 gold medals. ■



Geet Sethi holds nine world titles in Billiards & Snooker and is the co-founder of Olympic Gold Quest (www.olympic-goldquest.com).